of cowardice". Dipke thanked him. Yet, neither this statement nor Rahul's earlier assertion that "all protests are one" mentioned the CJP by name. This is perhaps because the Congress wants to lead the broader agitation without formally acknowledging the CJP as an equal partner. Publicly, the Congress is accommodating. "Whoever they are, whoever is supporting them, this is immaterial right now, as long as they are fighting," says Khera. Privately, the calculations differ. A Congress leader says the CJP is not yet an electoral threat but could become one if it forms a party or contests elections. Until then, he says, "they can have a free run".

The CJP, meanwhile, is wary of both state suppression and Congress absorption. Dipke calls it a "political pressure group" that welcomes party support but rejects integration into an INDIA-led campaign. After October 10, he warned that "by treating different protests differently, the government creates suspicion and mistrust". Ranka explains the strategy. "Cooperation does not always have to be on the same platform, at the same time. There must be pressure from various angles."

THE CENTRE'S PLAYBOOK

The government's response was shaped by its experience in July. Then, it had allowed the CJP to occupy Jantar Mantar for weeks and march on Parliament before a lathi charge left more than 100 students injured. Images of the police action generated sympathy and swelled the protests. Within weeks, Pradhan was out of the education ministry and Modi had conceded every demand. The BJP's assessment was that its mistake lay less in using force than in allowing the movement time and space to assemble, attract sympathy and dominate public attention. "They do not want any visuals like the last time," says Neelanjan Sircar of the Centre for Policy Research. October 10 was designed to prevent that. There was no lathi charge. Most detainees were released by evening, while the three CJP leaders were freed the next morning.

The second element of the strategy concerns Kumar, on whom the government has far less room for manoeuvre. A BJP insider told INDIA TODAY that any action against Kumar would be interpreted as an admission that elections had been manipulated, undermining the legitimacy of the government itself.



"The nation has understood Rahul Gandhi's plan to save infiltrators under the pretext of opposing SIR"

AMIT SHAH
Union Home Minister



"Gyanesh Kumar will go. This government will go. Then the repair of democracy will begin"

RAHUL GANDHI
Congress leader; LoP, Lok Sabha



"It doesn't matter who protests, where they protest or who they protest with. What matters is that we, as citizens of this country, refuse to remain silent"

ABHIJEET DIPKE
Founder and convenor, CJP

Kumar, a former home ministry official who helped draft the legislation abrogating Article 370, also enjoys constitutional protection. A CEC can be removed only through a process similar to that required for the impeachment of an SC judge. The government, therefore, has little incentive to move against him.

The third element is a carefully calibrated division of labour. Shah has assumed responsibility for the political defence of the SIR. His accusation that Rahul is shielding the "*ghuspaithiyas* (infiltrators)" seeks to change the terms of the debate. The argument also makes Shah the principal target of the Opposition's attacks, keeping Modi largely outside the line of fire. BJP president Nitin Nabin's allegation of the involvement of "foreign forces" might appear reflexive, but the party's internal assessment suggests that, unlike in July, this is resonating with its core supporters.

The fourth element is the most calculated. The BJP is relaxed about protests by established parties, and detaining Opposition leaders for a few hours costs it little. What worries it is the CJP's influence on young people outside party structures. So, the cockroaches are treated as a security problem with 'foreign links', while the Congress is allowed to march near the SC and dismissed as a sore loser.

THE SCALES OF JUSTICE

There is, however, one element the government cannot fully control: the judiciary. On October 5, Chief Justice Surya Kant rejected the ECI's claim that the SC had approved its modified Form 6 declaration. On October 11, Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana issued notice on a contempt plea concerning the lockdown and ordered the restoration of metro, rail and internet services. The courts, which the government might have hoped would provide institutional cover for the SIR, have begun raising questions of their own.

The government may well win the battle of the barricades and keep Kumar in office, but every sealed street hands its opponents a fresh grievance, and the SC may eventually step in, deciding how long the umpire will escape scrutiny. The Congress has found a potent issue, but must show organisational strength to sustain the fight. The CJP has the energy to survive, but not yet the leverage to force change. For now, a prolonged conflict seems likely, with the BJP banking on wearing its opponents down. ■